

The Civil War

Wilmer Mclean

- A successful grocer and sugar distributor to both the North and the South.
- His brick home in Manassas VA was the site of first major land battle of war, the first battle of Bull Run in July 1861.
- Home was commandeered by Confederate General Pierre Gustave Beauregard to serve as his headquarters during the battle, and was later damaged by Union shelling and still later it was taken over by Union General Irwin McDowell, as his Headquarters.
- What of Wilmer Mclean? Eager to escape the ravages of war, he abandoned his home in Manassas and moved his family and over 100 miles south to Appomattox Courthouse, VA and built a new brick home.



Brick home in
Manassas VA

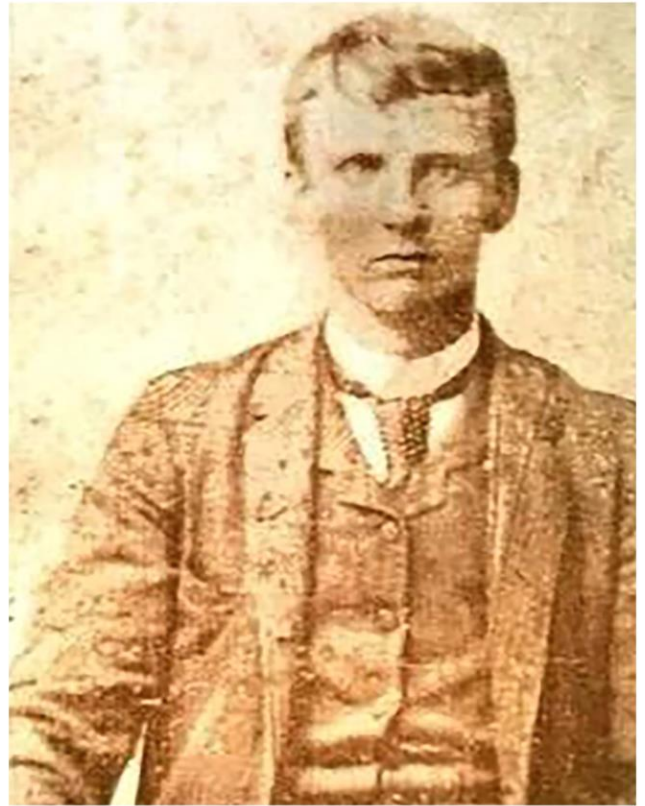
- In the early spring of 1865, it was becoming apparent that the South had, for all intents and purposes, lost the war, and the talk of a southern surrender was turning into a reality.
- When in early April Lee sent word to General Grant that he would, in fact, sign surrender documents, Grant directed his aides to find a suitable location for the surrender signing.
- After a brief search, the site of a beautiful brick home was decided upon. And who was the owner of this beautiful brick home? None other than Wilmer McLean, who had fled Manassas VA five years earlier to escape the ravages of that first major battle of the war.
- Thus the front parlor Wilmer's beautiful home became the site of Confederate General Robert E. Lee's surrender of the southern armies to Union General Ulysses Grant on April 9th, 1865, leading Wilmer McLean to say that "The War began in my front yard and ended in my front parlor".
- Thus ends the Civil War, that saw 620,000 casualties, or one out of every four men and boys who served during the war.

Appomattox
Courthouse



Lt. George E. Dixon

- In 2002, when lead researcher Maria Jacobsen, examining the area close to the remains of the sub's Officer, (later identified as Lt. George E. Dixon), found a misshapen \$20 gold piece, minted in 1860, with the inscription "Shiloh April 6, 1862, My Life Preserver G.E.D." on a sanded-smooth area of the coin's reverse side, and a forensic anthropologist found a healed injury to Lt. Dixon's hip bone.
- Traces of lead were also found on the dented coin. The findings matched a family legend that Dixon's Sweetheart had given him the coin to protect him. Dixon had the coin with him in his trouser's watch pocket at the Battle of Shiloh, where he was wounded in the thigh on 6 April 1862.



- The bullet struck the coin in his pocket, saving his leg and possibly his life. He had the gold coin engraved and carried it with him as a lucky charm.





A Revolution in Naval Warfare



“The Final Mission”



This stamp honoring the battle between the USS *Monitor* and CSS *Virginia* was issued June 29, 1995 in Gettysburg, Pennsylvania.

The Civil War produced dramatic advancements in naval technology. The lack of a formal navy forced Southern leaders to be innovative. For example, the Confederacy engineered developments in sea mines, constructed *David* class semi-submersible “torpedo boats,” and promoted ironclad warship technology. When the USS *Monitor* and the CSS *Virginia* battled each other to a draw in an 1862 naval engagement at Hampton Roads, Virginia, it was the first-ever battle between ironclad warships. It nearly left the world’s wooden-hulled fighting ships obsolete, as few all-wood ships were produced after this demonstration of technological prowess.

The South’s most spectacular naval innovation was the submarine *H.L. Hunley* — the first submarine to sink a warship in combat. Developed by New Orleans inventor Horace Hunley, who died testing the craft, the *Hunley* carried an eight-man crew and was armed with a spar torpedo, an explosive charge attached to a long pole that could be affixed to the front of the craft. On the night of February 17, 1864, the *Hunley* sank the 1,240-ton warship USS *Housatonic* in waters off Charleston, South Carolina. The *Housatonic* was the *Hunley*’s first and last victim: the Confederate submarine sank after the attack, and its entire crew was lost. For more than 135 years, the *Hunley* remained missing — until it was finally recovered in 2000.

About the Mort Künstler art... In “The Final Mission,” the crew of the Confederate submarine *H.L. Hunley*, commanded by Lieutenant George Dixon, prepares for what will prove to be the innovative vessel’s last mission.



Surrender at Appomattox



“Salute of Honor”



This stamp commemorating the centennial of the surrender at Appomattox was issued April 9, 1965 in Appomattox, Virginia.

The end came at a place called Appomattox. General Robert E. Lee and his Army of Northern Virginia — its ranks drastically reduced to barely 20,000 troops — pushed westward through Virginia, pursued by General Ulysses S. Grant and the 120,000-man Army of the Potomac. Forced to give up the defense of Richmond and still reeling from the loss at Sayler’s Creek, Lee led his army toward Danville in an attempt to join General Joseph E. Johnston’s depleted army for a united stand.

It was not to be. Cut off and cornered near the rural crossroads community of Appomattox Court House, Lee chose to surrender rather than needlessly sacrifice more lives. On April 9, 1865, he signed surrender terms with Grant in a farmhouse parlor at Appomattox. Three days later, his troops stacked weapons before the assembled ranks of the Union army. Elsewhere, other Southern armies would follow Lee’s example. As the Confederates approached the surrender site at Appomattox, a Union officer — General Joshua L. Chamberlain — ordered the Northern troops to salute Lee’s army. The Southern soldiers returned the compliment — and America’s bloodiest war ended in a joint salute by former foes.

About the Mort Künstler art... “Salute of Honor” depicts the dramatic moment when Union troops saluted General Robert E. Lee’s surrendering soldiers at Appomattox.